

FS 415 - Reading Review #2

The emergence of global television formats has sparked a lively and complex debate, highlighting concerns about cultural homogenization alongside the celebration of a more nuanced, interconnected world. Critics fear the dawn of a uniform monoculture, primarily influenced by the dominant Western media, which produces and exports a repetitive and formulaic type of content. This concern is articulated by Mikos (2015), who notes, "*Germany, being the largest TV market in Europe, predominantly imports television programming, especially in the fiction and entertainment segments, more than it exports*" (p. 694). This statement underscores the potential for a one-sided cultural influence. Conversely, there exists an argument for a more complex cultural interaction characterized by both "global localization" and "local globalization." Iwabuchi (2015) provides a compelling counterpoint, suggesting that the process is not merely about adapting the global to fit the local but also about embedding the local within the global. He explains, "*what is being promoted is not simply 'global localization'... but also 'local globalization' that makes audiences feel 'glocal,' that is, a sense of participation in a global society through the reciprocated enjoyable recognition of local (in most cases, synonymous to 'national') specificities articulated through shared formats*" (Iwabuchi, 2015, p. 34). This perspective illuminates the potential for a richer, reciprocal cultural exchange, where global formats are adapted in ways that celebrate local uniqueness while fostering a sense of belonging to a broader global community.

This essay contends that the intricate tapestry of contemporary television is most comprehensively understood through the prism of critical regionalism. This theoretical lens posits that global television shows serve not as stringent models but as springboards for inspiration, thereby cultivating a milieu that champions local ingenuity and plurality. Critical regionalism facilitates the creation of a kaleidoscope of culturally distinct content, underpinned by a shared narrative vernacular, which ultimately positions the television industry as a vibrant nexus where global and local narratives intersect and interweave. This fusion not only fosters a deeper cultural understanding but also enriches the diversity of the global media landscape. Specifically, this essay will explore how critical regionalism manifests in the adaptation of television content, the audience's role in shaping television narratives, and the challenges and opportunities posed by the global-local dynamic in television production and consumption.

The transnationalization of television illustrates how local cultures adapt their content for global appeal while preserving their unique identities, demonstrated by Turkish dramas and Nordic

Noir. Turkish producers focus on universally appealing themes, consciously avoiding national or cultural specifics to enhance global marketability, a strategy highlighted by Yesil (2013): "*Turkish producers have focused on developing the kinds of universally appealing themes and genre elements... avoid associating their characters with any particular Turkish national, ethnic or cultural referents emphasizing markers such as physical beauty, modern lifestyles and consumption*" (Yesil, 2013, p. 52). This approach is showcased in series like *Forbidden Love* and *A Thousand Nights*, which feature lavish settings and universal themes of love and betrayal. Yesil (2013) stresses that this strategy aims to increase the marketability of their products (Yesil, 2013, p. 52).

However, the pursuit of critical regionalism is not without its challenges. Media conglomerates, driven by profit motives, often prioritize content with broad global appeal, potentially at the expense of regional distinctiveness. Economic pressures can further complicate the balance between catering to international markets and preserving local identity. For instance, the need to attract advertising revenue can lead to the dilution of regional elements to appeal to a wider audience. Such dynamics underscore the intricate negotiation between global and regional imperatives in crafting content that resonates with audiences worldwide.

This essay argues that the success of TV shows across cultures highlights a fundamental concept: the global TV landscape flourishes through a combination of adaptation and innovation, underpinned by the principle of critical regionalism. Through this lens, producers tailor content for local tastes while fostering a rich, global cultural dialogue. This approach not only diversifies the international media landscape but also emphasizes the importance of preserving local identity in a global context. The notion of hybridity, crucial to critical regionalism, is vividly illustrated by shows like *Magnificent Century*, which merge global formats with distinct local flavours, appealing to audiences by intertwining historical narratives with Turkish cultural nuances (Özalpman & Sarikakis, 2018, p. 251). Despite its lavish production and storytelling akin to Hollywood, *Magnificent Century* primarily promotes a pro-capitalistic view. This emphasis suggests the series prioritizes commercial success over challenging dominant narratives, illustrating the complex interplay between economic goals and cultural influence in global media.

As the landscape of global media continues to evolve, the concept of "contra-flow" emerges as a critical lens through which to examine the challenges posed to Western-dominated narratives. Sakr (2007) contends that true contra-flows should not merely exist but actively and critically oppose the dominant status quo, a standard that global media movements have yet to consistently meet. This assertion calls for a nuanced understanding of the role of global media in cultural exchange, as it

navigates the complex dynamics of cultural and ideological diversity (Özalpman & Sarikakis, 2018, p. 251).

“When Japanese anime, India’s Bollywood, Brazilian bossa nova, Latin American telenovelas, and Korean wave or hallyu are conceptualized in the literature as ‘global counter-flows’, ‘multiple flows’ or ‘non-mainstream media flows’, the problematic of essentialist notions of nationalism, cultural notions and logic of purity as static global public sphere come to light” (Özalpman & Sarikakis, 2018, p. 251). Özalpman & Sarikakis (2018) note that these cultural phenomena underscore the vibrancy of the global public sphere (p. 251), highlighting the fluid nature of global media exchange. Further stating, that global media phenomena, contribute richly to the global cultural mosaic, yet their role as agents of ideological change is intricate and multifaceted. By delving into the nuances of global media hybridity, we can discern how these narratives navigate between disrupting the status quo and conforming to commercial imperatives.

Conversely, Nordic Noir adopts a unique approach, prioritizing a regional aesthetic and narrative style that is distinct from Hollywood, as Creeber (2015) notes: *‘However, what makes Nordic Noir so distinctive is the sense of realism embedded in its very fabric.’* (Creeber, 2015, p. 24). This genre's long-form narrative structure and complexity engage audiences deeply, allowing for the development of intricate storylines over time. Creeber (2015) states, *‘Long-form whodunnits clearly keep audiences hooked over a large number of episodes, but they also allow for a greater narrative complexity to gradually develop over time’* (Creeber, 2015, p. 23).

In the sphere of contemporary television, Danish TV dramas stand as a testament to the impact of critical regionalism on the global stage. Shows like *The Killing* and *Borgen* have transcended borders, captivating audiences worldwide with their innovative storytelling and transnational appeal. Esser (2015) attributes their success to a unique blend of local storytelling and high production values, stating that *‘the distinctive use of landscape (including the aural) to underline characters’ emotional and mental conditions and the ‘radical tele-visual style’, which mimics cinematic aesthetics through the ‘abiding use of dark colours and dim lighting’, ‘lurking camera placements’ and ‘rainy autumn scenes’*” (p. 414). This approach not only underscores the effectiveness of leveraging local landscapes and cultural nuances but also demonstrates how such strategies can resonate with global audiences, thereby exemplifying the principles of critical regionalism in action.

Active audience engagement further strengthens the concept of critical regionalism in television. Esser (2017) explores how UK audiences interact with Danish TV dramas, actively interpreting and integrating these shows through their cultural lenses, thus transforming them into rich,

context-specific narratives. This shift from passive consumption to active participation underscores the role of audiences in imbuing content with meaning, as they "*actively interpret shows like Danish crime dramas through their cultural lenses, projecting their anxieties and interpretations onto the narratives*" (Esser, 2017, p. 415). The success of these dramas in the UK, attributed to their quality and strategic production choices, illustrates the changing dynamics of international TV flows, moving beyond audience passivity and challenging notions of content universality (Esser, 2017).

Conversely, Nordic Noir adopts a unique approach, prioritizing a regional aesthetic and narrative style that is distinct from Hollywood, as Creeber (2015) notes: '*However, what makes Nordic Noir so distinctive is the sense of realism embedded in its very fabric.*' (Creeber, 2015, p. 24). This genre's long-form narrative structure and complexity engage audiences deeply, allowing for the development of intricate storylines over time. Creeber (2015) states, '*Long-form whodunnits clearly keep audiences hooked over a large number of episodes, but they also allow for a greater narrative complexity to gradually develop over time*' (Creeber, 2015, p. 23). The success of Nordic Noir abroad exemplifies the potency of regional storytelling in enriching the global television landscape. Creeber (2015) describes it as a blend of "*bleak naturalism, desolate locations, and melancholic detectives*" (p. 21), setting a unique tone in television drama. Shows like *The Bridge* and *The Killing* embody Nordic Noir's style, with their slow pacing and minimal dialogue enhancing its visual storytelling (Creeber, 2015, p. 24). The genre's translation across cultures, such as the British *Wallander*, shows mixed success, underlining the need for careful adaptation to maintain its essence and the importance of setting in reflecting emotional depth (Creeber, 2015, p. 25). Nordic Noir proves that regional narratives can significantly impact the global TV landscape, blending local sensibilities with broad themes and pioneering storytelling methods.

Localization practices are pivotal in fostering critical regionalism within the global television landscape, striking a delicate balance between preserving local distinctiveness and ensuring global appeal. This balance is exemplified in the adaptation of *The Office* into Germany's *Stromberg*, where the incorporation of local humor and cultural nuances significantly deepens the original's connection with its new audience. Mikos (2015) emphasizes this approach, stating, "*local producers inject humor and cultural references specific to their audience, transforming the original format to resonate with domestic viewers*" (Mikos, 2015, p. 694).

The concept of cultural proximity, as discussed by Straubhaar, sheds light on the audience's inclination towards content that reflects their local experiences, a preference that varies across different markets. This leads to innovative cultural adaptations where global formats are customized to align

with local tastes and norms (Mikos, 2015, p. 696), epitomizing the challenge of critical regionalism in achieving a balance between universal appeal and local specificity.

Supporting a broader argument, the successful globalization of television content hinges on its ability to blend universal themes with regional identity. The adaptation of *The Office* into Germany's *Stromberg* serves as a prime example of critical regionalism in action, preserving the original's humor while tailoring it to suit local preferences. Mikos (2015) elucidates this phenomenon in his analysis of how *Stromberg* became a classic sitcom by adapting British humor and style to the local market (Mikos, 2015, p. 695). Furthermore, the global success of British TV comedies and Bollywood, as noted by Bosanquet (2007) and Thussu (2008) respectively, underscores the dynamic nature of the industry and its capacity for cultural exchange beyond Western dominance. These examples highlight the potential for diverse content to resonate across different regions, showcasing the industry's ability to foster cross-cultural dialogue (Bosanquet, 2007, p. 90; Thussu, 2008, p. 109).

Global formats play a crucial role in fostering a broader dialogue in contemporary television and film, with hybrid narratives like *Delhi 6* challenging singular cultural representations and promoting cross-cultural understanding. Bhatawadekar (2011) highlights this dynamic, emphasizing the film's role in critiquing dominant narratives and presenting diverse representations that explore the complexities of Indian identity and diasporic connections (p. 247). Thussu (2008) further complements this perspective by highlighting Bollywood's global impact, noting its role in bringing Indian stories to an international audience and enriching global cultural exchanges (p. 97). The collective work of Thussu and Bhatawadekar advocates for critical regionalism within contemporary television and film, a paradigm where global formats become platforms for local creativity, allowing non-Western media to challenge and diversify the global narrative. Thussu's discussion on Bollywood's globalization exemplifies this, illustrating how local stories captivate worldwide audiences and promote cultural exchange. Bhatawadekar's analysis of *Delhi 6* further supports this view, showcasing local productions' ability to critique dominant narratives and present diverse representations.

This shift towards critical regionalism enables the integration of local creativity with global media, fostering a vibrant, diverse landscape. Instead of cultural homogenization, this dynamic encourages a rich mix of global narratives, blending local specificity with broad appeal and enhancing cross-cultural dialogue. Bosanquet and Bore's analysis of British TV comedies, especially *The Office*, underscores critical regionalism's role in achieving international success by sensitively adapting content to local nuances. Bore's study on the reception of *The Office* highlights the impact of cultural specificity on audience engagement, demonstrating how national differences, such as Norwegians'

comfort with subtitles and the British reliance on them, influence content reception. This complexity in global content consumption emphasizes the importance of recognizing cultural uniqueness in the international spread of television formats.

The rise of global television formats, as seen in the international adaptations of *The Office* and the global reach of Bollywood, challenges the traditional dominance of Western media narratives, fostering richer cultural exchange and understanding. Critical regionalism, which advocates for content that combines local relevance with universal themes, plays a crucial role in this process. This approach not only preserves local identities but also contributes to a more diverse and vibrant global media landscape, promoting global interconnectedness while celebrating cultural diversity.

In conclusion, by embracing a framework that prioritizes diverse narratives and cultural perspectives, the television industry can cultivate a richer and more inclusive global media landscape. This approach not only fosters deeper global connections but also transforms audience engagement from passive consumption to active participation. Viewers become integral contributors, interpreting content through their cultural lenses and adding depth to the narrative tapestry. While challenges remain due to the dominance of certain media centers and industry pressures, the commitment to a more pluralistic and dynamic television landscape holds the promise of fostering greater understanding and dialogue among global audiences. Ultimately, this evolution in television underscores its role as a powerful medium for cultural exchange, capable of bridging divides and enriching the global cultural fabric.

References

- Mikos, Lothar. "From The Office to Stromberg: adaptation strategies in German television." *Continuum: Journal of Media & Cultural Studies*, 29.5 (2015): 694–705.
- Bosanquet, Tim. "England's Dreaming (And Laughing): And What Australia Can Learn From It." *Metro Magazine* 151 (2006): 90-97.
- Iwabuchi, Koichi. "Japan in the global television format business." *Television across Asia: Television industries, programme formats and globalization*, edited by Michael Keane and Albert Moran, 35-52. *London: Routledge*, (2004): 21-35.
- Esser, Andrea. "Form, platform and the formation of transnational audiences: A case study of how Danish TV drama series captured television viewers in the United Kingdom." *Critical Studies in Television: The International Journal of Television Studies*, University of Roehampton, (2007): 411-429.
- Creeber, Glen. "Killing Us Softly: Investigating the aesthetics, philosophy and influence of Nordic Noir television." *The Journal of Popular Television* 3.1 (2015): 21-35.
- Özalpman, Dilek, and Katharine Sarikakis. "The Politics of Pleasure in Global Drama: Producing and consuming global TV drama." *The handbook of global media research*, edited by Ingrid Volkmer, 248-262. Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell, 2012.
- Thussu, Daya Kishan. "The globalization of Bollywood: The hype and hope." In *Global Bollywood*, edited by Kavoori, A and Punathambekar, 97-114. New York University Press, (2008): 97-113.
- Yesil, Bilge. "Transnationalization of Turkish Dramas: Exploring the convergence of local and global market imperatives." *Global Media and Communication* 9.1 (2013): 51-70.
- Bore, Inger-Lise Kalviknes. "Transnational TV Comedy Audiences." *Television & New Media* 12.4 (2011): 347-369.